WINNING OVER THE WEST

GUJARAT

HARDIK PATEL
From: Congress to BJP in June 2022
USP: Influential Patidar leader and former working president of PCC

ASHVIN KOTWAL
From: Congress to BJP in May 2022
USP: An influential tribal leader with considerable influence among Adivasis in Sabarkantha district

JAWAHAR CHAVDA
From: Congress to BJP in March 2019
USP: Won as Congressman in 2017, quit to join BJP in 2019 and was immediately made tourism minister in Vijay Rupani cabinet

RAGHAVJI PATEL
From: Congress to BJP in September 2019
USP: A four-term Congress MLA, he is an influential Patidar leader from Kutch. He is now the state minister for agriculture

BRIJESH MERJA
From: Congress to BJP in June 2019
USP: Influential in the Morbi area, he is now minister of state for labour and employment

GOA



VISHWAJIT RANE
From: Congress to BJP in March 2017
USP: Son of former Goa CM and Congress veteran Pratapsingh Rane, he resigned from the Congress after the 2017 Goa polls to join the BJP. Has been a minister in the BJP government since. After the 2022 polls, his wife Deviya Rane became a legislator as well

ATANASIO MONSERRATE
From: Congress to BJP in 2019
USP: Engineered a revolt in the Congress along with nine other legislators, joined BJP along with wife Jennifer. She was made revenue minister. Atanasio is now a minister for revenue in the Pramod Sawant cabinet

SUBHASH SHIRODKAR
From: Congress to BJP in October 2018
USP: A powerful Bhandari community member, he is cooperatives minister in Pramod Sawant's cabinet

MAHARASHTRA

★ **NARAYAN RANE**
From: Maharashtra Swabhiman Paksha to BJP in October 2020
USP: Has considerable influence in the Konkan region and is minister for MSME in PM Modi's government. A former CM of the state, Rane was earlier with the Shiv Sena and then with the Congress

RADHAKRISHNA VIKHE-PATIL
From: Congress to BJP in September 2019
USP: A five-time Congress MLA, he was leader of the opposition during Devendra Fadnavis' tenure. His father Balasaheb Vikhe Patil was an eight-term Congress MP.



Hardik Patel

a conscious effort to look at the section of people who have not been adequately represented in the party. It is based on who can deliver results and make the BJP stronger ideologically. We are also cautious that those we select fit into the basic framework of the BJP thought process and look at whether they can be mainstreamed and assimilated into the party. There is due diligence done. It's our standard operating procedure." Nadda calls it part of the BJP's continuous process of expansion and is clear that the party's promise of *sabka saath, sabka vikas, sabka viswas* and *sabka prayas* is not an empty slogan. He says, "This is our mantra and we are following it in letter and spirit."

Even in his broad-brush description, it's clear that the saffron strategists are alive to the complexities of how a behemoth-like BJP must look at new recruits. They are, in short, working to a precise plan—or rather, a menu of tactical manoeuvres, from which they take out what's logically most suitable to a given situation. Underlying the whole movement is a clear strategy of expansion. What's to be borne in mind is that this expansion is not just something happening on the vertical